Labor Day

By Milan Stitt

INTRODUCTION

DANIEL: *Have you ever felt like you're being watched?*
THEA: *Have you ever stood and just watched someone?*
DANIEL: *You don't know who, you don't know where. But you know they're watching.*
THEA: *You watch and you wonder what's going on in his life.*
BOTH: *(Overlapping) it feels really / you feel sort of…(together) Strange.*
DANIEL: *"Labor Day"*
THEA: *By Milan Stitt*

(The pay phone at the corner begins to ring. DANIEL is uncertain what to do about the ringing. It's insistent.)

DANIEL: You've got a wrong number. This is a pay phone. *(There s no response.)* Hello? Can you hear me? *(He hangs up, returns to bus stop, looks for a bus to arrive. The phone starts ringing again. He tries to ignore it … but can't.)* Listen, this is a pay phone. *(He listens carefully. Is someone on the line?)* Is someone there? If you're there, you got a wrong number.

THEA'S VOICE: Maybe not. *(Lights come up on THEA, a striking woman. She's on her 17th floor terrace, looking down at DANIEL through a high-powered telescope.)*

DANIEL: What?

THEA: *(Very judgmental)* You sound OK. *(Annoyed, DANIEL hangs up. THEA pushes the redial button on her portable phone. The pay phone rings and rings. Finally, DANIEL can't resist.)*

DANIEL: Look. Whoever you are, I'm not interested.

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THEA: It's going to be a long time before a bus comes. We could wait together.

DANIEL: Yeah? What are you waiting for?

THEA: The dark. To go to work. Whatever's left.

DANIEL: *(About to hang up)* Forget it. I don't pay for it. And I wish you'd stop ringing this

THEA: Sex is easy.

DANIEL: Is it?

THEA: Anyone can accomplish that. *(Disappointed)* I guess I knew you'd think that was it.

DANIEL: What am I supposed to think? Is this what you do here in what-do-ya-call-it?

THEA: Chelsea. *(A moment)* Understand, we're never going to meet. *(A moment)* So don't worry, OK? *(He looks up the avenue for a bus.)* The buses are on holiday schedule.

DANIEL: *(Looking up at buildings)* You can see me, can't you?

THEA: Does it make you nervous?

DANIEL: *(It definitely does!)* No. Where are you?

THEA: You'll never know, so you can say whatever you want.

DANIEL: I have nothing to say, lady.

THEA: *(Disappointed)* Oh, you look like the kind of person who never mind. Must be the distance. That's what I get for trying something different. *(She hangs up. The more he thinks about it, the angrier he gets. He stares at phone, daring it to ring He looks up at buildings... points to phone ... waits. It rings. He s surprised ... hesitates ... then grabs it.)*

DANIEL: I do have things to say. But not to you! *(He hangs up, looks for bus, hut*

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does not return to bus stop. He won't give her the satisfaction of looking up at buildings again. The phone rings. He picks it up. She hangs up. He yells at the building) That's very childish! *(He stalks over to the bus stop. The phone rings. He won't answer it. It keeps ringing. He answers it.)* I can't stand unanswered phones.

THEA: That's why I selected you.

DANIEL: Selected me?

THEA: It's been a long weekend. The usual mix-up ... and galleys*(Corrects herself, lest he be able to identify her.)* Some work that was supposed to be delivered never arrived.

DANIEL: Are you a writer?

THEA: Pardon?

DANIEL: Galleys. Aren't those what writers correct?

THEA: Do you want me to be a writer?

DANIEL: I don't care. Whatever.

THEA: *(Annoyed)* I'm not indiscriminate, you know? *(A moment)* You're the first one who looked ... worth it.

DANIEL: *(A come-on)* You like the way I look? *(A moment)* How long have you been at this?

THEA: Not long. *(A moment)* My son's starting at one of those generic universities. Ohio or Indiana. The ones with football. Something or other at Urbana.

DANIEL: Illinois.

THEA: I should know, shouldn't I? But once you put information in computers and these automatic dialers you forget it. *(A moment)* He left Thursday to avoid the traffic. *(A moment)* The Time's as empty as the city on these long

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weekends ... except for the sales. And I don't have time to go running around for bargains. I did the crossword for once. Why anyone would think it's amusing to know a five-letter word for an Egyptian goddess totally escapes me. The other excitement was running

out of half and half. On the way back from Dagostino's, I copied the number of your phone down there.

DANIEL: Big cities are a bitch. You're pretty lonely, eh?

THEA: No. Realistic, and therefore bored. We're alone from the moment of conception. Except maybe twins ... but they're aberrations. Lonely is only possible if you think something else is possible; it isn't. We live by ourselves, with ourselves until the time runs out.

DANIEL: How often do the buses run here?

THEA: I don't use buses.

DANIEL: Neither do I. But I've seen three cabs all the way up from Center Street. And they were off duty.

THEA: You work in Wall Street?

DANIEL: *(Echoing her)* Do you want me to? *(No response)* I flew in yesterday. There's a conference tomorrow. I figured I could use the weekend here to catch up on paperwork.

THEA: Workaholic?

DANIEL: When there's no work, I don't call strangers to avoid an empty life.

THEA: But you're talking. *(A moment)* Is your life empty? *(No response)* You can say whatever you want. *(No response)* In a civilized world, there would be numbers to call for intelligent conversation on holidays.

DANIEL: You can call for sex.

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THEA: But not for intellect. Do you call those numbers?

DANIEL: For sex?

THEA: I forgot. You don't have to.

DANIEL: Do you?

THEA: It's curious how in any conversation men turn so quickly to sex.

DANIEL: Faster than women?

THEA: Yes.

DANIEL: Talk. Let's see how long you can avoid it.

THEA: *(After a moment)* My life is not a vacuum. I don't have to fill it with sexual fantasies. *(Sees that he is looking for bus.)* And the only reason I happen to have a telescope to watch you being impatient is that I'm fascinated by celestial phenomena.

DANIEL: Voyeurism. Sex.

THEA: If it is, it's not particularly gratifying knowing what turns me on actually existed some billions of years ago and is just reaching me now.

DANIEL: Lacks immediacy?

THEA: Which I think is important to sex. So no, it's not voyeurism.

DANIEL: You're still talking about sex.

THEA: I'm answering your question ... about sex.

DANIEL: *(A moment)* I've never gotten the message of astronomy.

THEA: Have you looked?

DANIEL: I can't begin to understand it... and the scientists can't understand it. Black holes, time warps, exploding galaxies, why bother?

THEA: But that's the point.

DANIEL: Why add to the frustration?

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THEA: Reality isn't frustration.

DANIEL: Must be different in Chelsea than in Stevensville.

THEA: Is that on the East Coast?

DANIEL: No. It's one of those generic places. Near Chicago.

THEA: *(A moment)* Looking at the stars ... it's addictive.

DANIEL: Addictions are escapes. Not reality.

THEA: No. It's wonderful. The stars ... they keep me in my place. Probably proves God is a man.

DANIEL: Does it?

THEA: What's left to me in an ever expanding universe is this small place. My small problems. Small responsibilities. I am not the center of the universe. I'm reminded that most of what is I cannot control or change. Nor does anyone expect me to. That's important to know. Essential. Therefore, addictive.

DANIEL: I get that when I'm at the lake.

THEA: I see. You limit your philosophical inquiries to two weeks a year.

DANIEL: *(Enjoying the exchange)* No, anytime I look out a window in my house. The lake never looks quite the same. I limit myself to that which I can touch ... maybe even understand. Outer space to reach inner space seems a convoluted trip to me. If not just an escape. Tranquility is what you do, not what you think. Easy things. Right here. Now. Golf when there's no one but me to leave tracks in the dew. Fishing for hours when you know the fish couldn't possibly be biting. Gathering driftwood that's too interesting to burn. Not talking, not thinking, just being.

THEA: *(A moment)* I'm not going to invite you up.

DANIEL: Sex, again?

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THEA: Is that the only way people can wait together?

DANIEL: At least, it's waiting closer.

THEA: You're very glib, for a man who 'does,' rather than 'thinks.' Why is there always such a distance between what we want to be and what we are? I hoped that distance would diminish with time.

DANIEL: So did I. *(A moment)* But I'm not coming up. In an over populated world, non-involvement is a social necessity.

THEA: And that suits you? *(Focusing telescope)* You don't have a wedding ring.

DANIEL: You want me to say I'll come up. So you can say no. That's the game.

THEA: I don't play games. I can't anymore. A belated social retardation has set in. *(Looking at sky)* There are a couple of stars. It's almost dark enough.

DANIEL: You're that old? You need candlelight? Scarves over the lamps?

THEA: *(After a moment)* I wish it were as simple as you think.

DANIEL: Isn't it?

THEA: Not anymore. *(She hangs up ... immediately regrets it, redials. He watches the phone ring for a moment, then returns to bus stop. The phone stops ringing. The light fades on THEA. He looks for a bus, returns to phone, looks up .., gestures for her to call. Lights come up on THEA who is now looking at the stars through the telescope. She can't see his gesture. Lights slowly fade to black.)*

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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